

Data Breach Case Study

Li
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Attack Category: Data Breach

Description: A data breach occurs when unauthorized individuals gain access to sensitive, protected, or confidential data. This can happen through various means, including hacking, insider threats, or lost devices.

Statistics: According to the 2022 IBM Cost of a Data Breach Report, the average cost of a data breach was approximately \$4.35 million.

Company Description and Breach Summary

Company: Equifax

Description: Equifax is one of the largest credit reporting agencies in the U.S., providing consumer credit data and analytics.

Incident Summary: In 2017, Equifax suffered a massive breach that exposed personal information of approximately 147 million individuals, including Social Security numbers, birth dates, and addresses.

Timeline

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Event 1

March 2017: Vulnerability in Apache Struts framework identified.

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Event 2

May 2017: Attackers exploit the vulnerability to gain access to Equifax's systems.

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Event 3

July 2017: Equifax detects unusual activity in its network.

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Event 4

September 2017: Equifax publicly announces the data breach.

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Event 5

October 2017: The Federal Trade Commission (FTC) begins an investigation.

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Event 6

2018: Equifax agrees to pay up to \$700 million in a settlement.

Vulnerabilities

Vulnerability 1

Unpatched software (Apache Struts).

Vulnerability 2

Lack of adequate intrusion detection systems.

Vulnerability 3

Insufficient access controls for sensitive data.

Vulnerability 4

Inadequate employee training on security protocols.

Costs and Prevention

Costs

- 1. Legal fees and settlements.
- 2. Increased cybersecurity measures.
- 3. Loss of consumer trust.
- etc.

Prevention

- 1. Regular software updates and patch management.
- 2. Implementing robust monitoring and detection systems.
- 3. Conducting regular security training for employees.
- etc.